

Caregiving and stress

Caring for infants and young children is stressful. This is further compounded by workload from working within or outside the home. Sometimes, women who are caring for children are also caring for elderly parents. This also worsens stress.

It is also worsened by personal circumstances such as poor economic situation, exposure to domestic violence, poor physical environment, experience of discrimination, poor access to health care that place additional stress on the caregiving process.

Stress causes the body to release stress hormones that cause inflammation and insulin resistance. This increases the likelihood of developing pre-diabetes, Type 2 diabetes and hypertension.

Coping with caregiving stress

1. **First**, recognize when you are stressed. Stress produces a lot of physical and behavioral signs and symptoms. This includes physical symptoms
 - Tight neck and shoulders
 - Back pain
 - Sleep difficulties
 - Tiredness or fatigue
 - Racing heartbeat or palpitations
 - Shakiness or tremors
 - Sweating
 - Ringing in ears
 - Dizziness or fainting
 - Choking sensation
 - Difficulty swallowing
 - Stomachache
 - Indigestion
 - Diarrhea or constipation
 - Frequent, urgent need to urinate
 - Loss of interest in sex
 - Restlessness

It also includes behavioral symptoms like;

Grinding of teeth

- “ Inability to complete tasks
- “ Overly critical attitude
- “ Bossiness
- “ Fidgeting
- “ Overuse of alcohol
- “ Emotional eating or overeating
- “ Fist clenching
- “ Changes in the amount of alcohol or food you consume
- “ Taking up smoking or smoking more than usual
- “ Increased desire to be with or withdraw from others
- “ Rumination (frequent talking or brooding about stressful situations)

Emotional symptoms of stress include;

- Crying
- “ Irritability
- “ Quick temper
- “ Anger
- “ Boredom
- “ Nervousness or edginess
- “ Feeling anxious
- “ Lack of meaning in life and pursuits
- “ Loneliness
- “ Unhappiness with no clear cause
- “ Depression
- “ Feeling powerless to change things

Cognitive symptoms of stress are;

- “ Continual worry
- “ Poor concentration
- “ Trouble remembering things
- “ Loss of sense of humor
- “ Indecisiveness
- “ Lack of creativity
- “ Trouble thinking clearly

2. Second, try to relax. A quick way to relax is by choosing something pleasant to focus on. It can be a song you enjoy, a short prayer or a short phrase. Then take deep breaths

Common relaxing techniques

Make sure you make out time to relax everyday. This creates a small escape from stressful situations. Here are tips to relax.

1. Breath Focus

This involves slow and deep breathing. Make sure to take your mind away from distressing thoughts.

2. Guided Imagery

Staying focused on pleasant mental images and thoughts. This helps to elicit relaxation.

3. Mindfulness meditation

This also involves taking deep breaths and staying focused on a sensations, sounds and thoughts without judging them. That is without asking why they are happening or what to do with them. This is a very relaxing practice if done at least 10 minutes a day

4. Repititions

Repeating a short prayer or phrase or song while taking deep breaths is equally relaxing.

Other relaxing activities are exercises, dancing, Tai-Chi and Yoga.